ENGLAND FOOTBALL

HELP & SUPPORT GUIDE

Leadership & Governance

Everything currently available under this pillar, and where to find it.

How to use this guide: each numbered block is one source of support. Text in **red** › is a link you can click to open.

1 Club Leadership Programme — WITH UCFB

Gives club leaders the tools, knowledge and networking opportunities to help them and their club thrive.

It applies modern sports models and thinking to large community clubs, including Men's National League System and Women's National League clubs.

View the Club Leadership Programme ›

2 Financial Controls — ENGLAND FOOTBALL

To move from surviving to thriving, a club's foundations need to be secure. Protecting the funds raised by members and volunteers is a collective responsibility, and clubs and leagues continue to be targeted for personal gain.

Four pillars give a simple framework for keeping money safe, transparent and where it belongs: in the game.

Read the Financial Controls guidance ›

3 Legal & governance support — THE FA AND MUCKLE LLP

Working with a national network of club consultants, the Muckle LLP team supports County FAs, leagues and clubs of all sizes across English football. The focus is governance and legal structures, including incorporation, CASC and charity status.

Visit The FA and Muckle LLP hub ›

FA BITESIZE GUIDES

- **Financial Controls ›**
- **Governance Standards ›**
- **Incorporation & Legal Structures ›**
- **Leadership ›**
- **Risk Management ›**
- **Special Tax Status & Trading ›**

DATA PROTECTION AND CLUB STRUCTURES

- **FA Data Protection Factsheets ›** For County FAs, leagues and clubs
- **FA Data Protection Templates ›** For County FAs, leagues and clubs
- **The FA's Guide to Club Structures ›** PDF guide

4 Video guides — THE CLUB HUB ON YOUTUBE

Football Club Governance with Muckle LLP is a playlist of short films for club leaders. **Watch the full playlist ›**

- **Managing data & risk at your football club ›**
- **Which legal structure should your football club have? ›**
- **How leadership can help shape a successful football club ›**
- **How to optimise your football club's finances ›**

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5 Tools & guidance

IN THE PLAYBOOK

Log in to the PlayBook to find the resources below. **Open the PlayBook ›**

VAT

VAT Assessment information for clubs

The specialist VAT advisory service from an independent sports VAT expert: how VAT affects clubhouse, changing room and pitch projects, and how to maximise recovery.

VAT guidance for clubs

A practical reference guide to the key principles: VAT registration, taxable and exempt income, VAT recovery and the implications of facility improvement projects.

VAT Flow Chart for clubs

A simple decision tool: whether to register for VAT, the VAT status of different income streams, and recovery opportunities in facility projects and club operations.

VAT Case Study Toolkit for clubs

Real-world club case studies with worked solutions, covering facility developments, grant-funded projects, VAT registration, fundraising and capital investment.

CLUB STRUCTURES

Club Structures Assistant

A free online tool, built by Muckle LLP (recommended Legal Professional Services to the Accredited Club Programme), that helps clubs assess their governance and legal structure and identify whether they need specialist support.

- Clubs answer an online questionnaire on their activities, governance and future plans, and are automatically placed in one of three levels by the support they need.
- A Process Guide is available in the PlayBook.

Open the Club Structures Assistant ›

Not for public sharing. A hidden link: signpost only to eligible clubs you are directly supporting.

Resource Sharing Agreement

Part of Better Everywhere and developed with Muckle LLP. For clubs where the senior section (the Senior Club) and the community or amateur section (the Junior Club) are housed in two separate legal entities.

- Puts an agreement in place for how the resources each entity holds are shared or used between them.
- Supports growing clubs adopting different structures, and the benefits and opportunities these bring.

TWO DOCUMENTS IN THE PLAYBOOK

- Toolkit: the Resource Sharing Agreement itself.
- Guidance Notes: to accompany the toolkit.

6 Workshops 2026

IN THE PLAYBOOK

Financial Controls and VAT 2026

WHO IT'S FOR

County FA staff, FA Club Consultants and club development practitioners.

WHAT IT COVERS

- Why financial controls matter and what good practice looks like across different club settings.
- How a club's legal structure influences its financial responsibilities.
- Budgeting, financial oversight, reporting requirements, tax implications and risk management.
- The role of technology in improving financial administration.

WHAT YOU TAKE AWAY

Practical checklists, review questions, case studies and digital tools to use straight away when supporting clubs.

Club Legal Structures and Governance 2026

WHO IT'S FOR

County FA staff, FA Club Consultants and senior club leaders, especially at clubs reviewing long-term plans, managing facilities, employing staff or planning to grow.

WHAT IT COVERS

- How legal status affects a club's growth, risk, investment, volunteer protection and access to funding.
- Advantages and limitations of each structure: unincorporated association, company limited by guarantee, company limited by shares, CIC and CIO.
- Incorporation: when it is appropriate and how it protects clubs, volunteers and assets.

WHAT YOU TAKE AWAY

Practical tools and decision-making frameworks to check whether a club's structure remains fit for purpose.

Both are aligned to the Thriving Community Clubs framework and use discussion, case studies and practical examples.

7 Maturity pathway resources

NEW IN THE PLAYBOOK

Added October 2026: 41 resources from the Leadership & Governance maturity pathway, for workforce use with clubs. Search by name or open the Leadership & Governance pillar. Templates come as a fillable PDF plus an editable PowerPoint or Word version. **Open the PlayBook ›**

VISION & STRATEGIC PLANNING

Our Journey So Far Template
Capture the club's history, milestones and ambitions; a good opener for vision work. (PDF + PowerPoint)

Strategic House Template
Vision, mission, strategic goals, objectives and values on one page. (PDF + PowerPoint)

Strategic House Example
A completed Strategic House for a community club. (PDF)

Strategic Goals Template
Turn one goal into actions, owners, timescales, costs and review points. (PDF + PowerPoint)

Strategic Project Plan
Map goals and major actions across the season, August to July. (PDF + PowerPoint)

Objective Template
Up to four objectives with key activities and measures. (PDF + PowerPoint)

SITUATIONAL ANALYSIS

PESTLE Analysis Template
Scan political, economic, social, technological, legal and environmental factors. (PDF + PowerPoint)

SWOT Analysis Template
Strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats. (PDF + PowerPoint)

Stakeholder Analysis Template
How the club engages each stakeholder group, and three actions to improve. (PDF + PowerPoint)

Audience Analysis Template
A 'who's in our circle' map of core, direct, indirect and other audiences. (PDF + PowerPoint)

Resources Analysis 1 & 2 Templates
Resources now vs needed in 3 to 5 years, then what gives the club an edge. (PDF + PowerPoint)

Club Organisational Structure
Map the people in each layer of the club, from board to groups. (PDF + PowerPoint)

RASCI Matrix Template
Who is Responsible, Accountable, Supporting, Consulted and Informed for each task. (PDF + PowerPoint)

COMMUNICATIONS

Strategic Communications: Think, Feel, Do
What each audience should think, feel and do. (PDF + PowerPoint)

Strategic Communications Plan
Messages, channels, timing and owners for each audience. (PDF + PowerPoint)

PEOPLE PLAN & BOARD RECRUITMENT

People Plan Checklist
Seven questions to test the board or committee's composition, skills and culture. (PDF)

Board or Committee Composition & Skills
Map the skills and experience the board has and needs. (PDF + PowerPoint (template); PDF (example))

Skills Matrix Template
Score each member against the skills the club needs. (PDF + Word)

Skills, Experience & Expertise Questionnaire
Self-assessment for each board or committee member. (Word)

Skills Audit Guidance
Six steps from identifying needs to a succession plan. (PDF)

Performance & Development Guidance
Objective setting, a season review timeline and development ideas. (PDF)

Dates of Terms of Board of Directors Template
Track terms of office and when they end. (PDF + PowerPoint)

Expected Vacancies & Skills Gaps Template
Plan for upcoming vacancies and the skills to recruit for. (PDF + PowerPoint)

Succession Plan Template
Key roles, likely successors and readiness. (PDF + Word)

Board or Committee Recruitment: Application Pack
Role information and application form for new members. (PDF + Word)

Role Profiles & Bios
Each key role with a short profile and bio of the holder. (PDF + PowerPoint)

GOVERNANCE & OPERATIONAL STRUCTURES

Governance Structure Template & Example
Board, officers, leads and committees as an organisation chart. (PDF + PowerPoint (template); PDF (example))

Operational Structure Template & Example
Who runs the club day to day, from board to operations team. (PDF + PowerPoint (template); PDF (example))

Club Teams & Age Groups Structure
Every team and age group, with the Secretary, Coach Developer and Safeguarding leads. (PDF + PowerPoint)

MEETINGS, CONFLICTS OF INTEREST & RISK

Board or Committee Agenda Template
Meeting notice and 19 standing agenda items. (PDF + Word)

Board or Committee Meeting Minutes Template
Attendance, apologies and an action table. (PDF + Word)

Declaration of Interests Template
Form for members to declare interests, with tick boxes. (PDF + Word)

Declaration of Interests Guidance Notes
What to declare and how to keep a register of interests. (PDF)

Risk Register Template
Likelihood and impact scores (1 to 5), risk score, controls and owner. (PDF + Word)

A Guide to Club Structures (FA and Muckle LLP)
Legal structures, tax status and incorporation step by step (2020 edition). (PDF)

CHANGE

Why Do You Want to Change? Template
Six questions to agree the case for change. (PDF + PowerPoint)

Kübler-Ross Change Model
How people react to change, and what leaders can do at each stage. (PDF)